Lesson 01: Introduction to Academic Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 1 Introduction to Academic Writing; Appendix A Non-Stop Non-Translation (NSNT) Free Writing with Additional Weekly Prompts.

In this lesson

You will learn what academic writing is, its four main characteristics, and ten wrong ideas about writing that are common among ESL students. You will also start a habit for the whole course: Non-Stop Non-Translation (NSNT) free writing, which trains you to think and write in English without translating. These are the foundations for every paragraph, essay and report you write in your psychology course.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Define academic writing and name the main purposes of writing.
- Explain the four characteristics of academic writing and how to achieve each one.
- Recognize the ten common misconceptions about writing and choose the advice that helps you most.
- Practise NSNT free writing, following its four steps.
- Write a short paragraph about academic writing or your own writing experience.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
academic writing	a formal, nonfictional written piece of work for learning, teaching, and researching	Students write paragraphs, essays, research papers, and lab reports.
nonfictional	about real facts and ideas, not invented stories	Fiction and movie scripts are not academic writing.
linear organization	ideas in a straight line: main idea first, then supporting ideas, then a conclusion	Academic writing in English uses a very linear organizational style.
formal	serious, standard English for study and work	Formal, standard English is expected.
col·LO·qui·al	informal	Colloquial and spoken English should not be used.
con·CISE	not repeating the same words and ideas unnecessarily	Being concise means not repeating the same words and ideas unnecessarily.
re·DUN·dant	wordy, repetitive (more than necessary)	Needless duplications of the same ideas may make your writing redundant.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
PROOF·read	read and check for mistakes	Always proofread your writing for accuracy.
re·VI·sion	a new copy showing improvement	Good writing takes time and repeated revisions.
com·po·SI·tion	a piece of writing such as an essay for a college course	You will be ready for higher-level compositions.
mis·con·CEP·tion	a wrong idea	The ten misconceptions are very common among ESL students.
plagiarism	copying other people's work and taking it as your own	You will easily fall into the temptation of plagiarism.
prompt	a topic for writing	Choose two topics from the Week 1 additional prompts.
NSNT free writing	writing in English nonstop, without translating	Try three minutes, four times a week.

Rules and explanations

What is writing for?

The simplest answer: to communicate meaning. People write for different purposes:

- **to inform:** news stories, technical manuals
- **to entertain:** fiction, movie scripts
- **in daily life:** a short reminder note, a party invitation, a love letter
- **at work:** meeting memos, business reports
- **in colleges and universities:** paragraphs, essays, research papers, lab reports. This last type is **academic writing**.

Four characteristics of academic writing

Characteristic	What it means	How to achieve it
1. Logical and direct	A linear style, like a vertical line: main idea → supporting ideas → conclusion.	State your focus early. Do not "hide" your point or give hints until the end.
2. Formal	Standard English.	Learn formal grammar and usage. Do not use colloquial or spoken English.
3. Clear	Readers can understand your thoughts.	Do not translate from your native language. Always proofread.
4. Concise	No unnecessary repetition.	Repeat a word or idea only when you need to emphasize a point.

Writing is a process. Almost no one writes perfectly on the first try, and there is no such thing as perfect writing. Good writing takes time, repeated revisions, patience and continuous effort.

Ten common misconceptions about writing

Read the full explanations in the lesson material (section IV). In short:

1. **"Translating sophisticated words and sentences makes my writing better."** No: meaning and clarity get lost. Start with the words and sentence structures you know. A simple text that readers understand is better than a difficult one they cannot follow.
2. **"I do not know what to write, so I google ideas."** Just start writing, and plan backwards from the due date. Relying on the Internet leads to plagiarism and limits your own thinking.
3. **"A general topic is easier."** Good writing is deep, not broad. Narrow the topic to a unique angle.
4. **"Prewriting is a waste of time."** Brainstorming gives you ideas; an outline helps you catch problems before you write.
5. **"I keep adding new things while I write."** First put the new idea into your outline and check that it supports the main idea.
6. **"Tutoring is only for weak students."** Tutoring is for every student; strong students use it most.
7. **"My professor will correct every error."** Professors often mark only the type of error; you learn to correct it yourself.
8. **"Family and friends are the best helpers."** They may do the work for you without explaining, so you do not learn from your mistakes.
9. **"Grammar is not important."** Grammar is the foundation of good writing.
10. **"I do not need to read in a writing class."** Good writers are almost always good readers.

For you: the book was written for students at Harper College in the U.S. Your "tutor" is your AI tutor, and your "professor" is the instructor of your psychology course.

NSNT free writing (Appendix A)

Why think in English while writing?

- No two languages are exactly the same, so meaning gets lost or misunderstood in direct translation.
- Translating takes longer, and academic study means a lot of reading and writing.
- "Old habits die hard": the longer you translate, the harder it is to stop.

Four steps

1. Use a special notebook or computer file and write the date. Write nonstop in English. Try three minutes, four times a week, then slowly write longer and more often. Use a timer.
2. Choose your own topic or a prompt. It is OK to wander to a different topic. Keep only one language in your mind: English.
3. If you run out of ideas, keep writing: "I don't know what more to write..." or "Monday, Tuesday..." Do not lift your pen or stop typing.

4. Do not worry about grammar and spelling, and do not stop to use a dictionary. Correct mistakes afterwards if you want.

The book's example (1/15/2022) is typical of the first days or weeks: short ideas, many mistakes, but all in English. Progress may take a semester or more, like building muscles in a gym.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no "is/are" in present-tense sentences such as "the teacher kind", so word-for-word translation often leaves out "be": "My teacher very kind" → "My teacher **is** very kind." - Arabic writing often joins many ideas with "and". In English academic writing, long chains of "and" make a text unclear and not concise; end the sentence and start a new one.

Practice

Exercise 1. Questions from the Warm-Up and the Unit Review Practice. Answer in full sentences. Use section II and section III of the lesson material.

1. What are the purposes of writing?
2. What is academic writing?
3. What are the characteristics of academic writing, and how can you achieve each one?

Exercise 2. Misconceptions and advice. Read the ten misconceptions in the lesson material (section IV). Match each misconception (1-10) with the advice from the unit summary (a-i). Some advice matches more than one misconception.

Misconceptions:

1. I translate sophisticated vocabulary and complex sentences from my native language to English so that my English writing looks much better.
2. I do not know what to write. I worry about my assignments a lot, and then I google to get some ideas.
3. The more general the topic is, the easier it is to write.
4. I like to start writing right away. Prewriting is a waste of time.
5. It is a good idea to keep adding new things while I am writing.
6. ESL tutoring is for students who are not doing well in the course.
7. My professor will correct every error in my writing.
8. My family and friends are the best people to help me improve my writing.
9. I will just focus on reading and writing courses in order to go to English 101. Grammar is not important.
10. Since it is a writing class, I do not need to read regularly.

Advice: a) Try not to translate from your native language. b) Do not rely on the information on the Internet. c) Explore your topic by brainstorming and then organize your ideas by outlining. d) Narrow down a general topic to a more specific one. e) Get help from your professor and ESL tutors. f) Be

proactive in contacting your professor regarding errors in your writing. g) Do not rely too much on the help of your family and friends. h) Study grammar. i) Read as much as you can.

11. Which misconceptions apply to you? Which advice will be the most helpful? Write three or four sentences.

Exercise 3. Vocabulary review. Match the words from the unit's flashcards with their meanings.

1. approach
2. duplication
3. entertain
4. manual
5. memo
6. scribble
7. well-versed

a) write quickly and informally b) a small book of instructions c) a way of thinking about and doing things d) provide music, stories, etc. for people to enjoy e) with beautiful language use f) a short message or report g) a copy, a repetition

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the eight Warm-Up questions from Unit 1 one at a time. After each answer, correct my grammar and tell me whether my English was formal or colloquial."
- "I will tell you which three misconceptions about writing apply to me. Ask me follow-up questions, then give me advice from the lesson."
- "Here is my NSNT free writing from today: [paste]. Do not correct it. Count the words and tell me which idea I could develop into a paragraph."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. Is it logical and direct, formal, clear and concise? Then list my grammar errors by type."
- "Give me five colloquial sentences about studying. I will rewrite them in formal, standard English, and you check them."

Writing task

Part 1: A paragraph (Unit Review Practice). Choose one topic and write one paragraph of about 150 to 200 words:

- What is academic writing? What are the characteristics of academic writing?
- What has been your best writing experience? Your most challenging writing experience?
- Which of the ten misconceptions apply to you? What advice will be the most helpful to you?

Put your main idea in the first sentence, explain it with two or three supporting ideas, and finish with a concluding sentence. Write directly in English; do not translate.

Part 2: NSNT free writing. Choose two Week 1 prompts from Appendix A (for example: What are your plans for this semester? How are you going to study differently from how you studied in the past? What does "academic honesty" mean to you? What are your expectations of this course?). Write nonstop for three to five minutes on each, without translating and without a dictionary.

Self-editing checklist (Part 1)

- Is my main idea in the first sentence (logical and direct)?
- Does every sentence explain the main idea?
- Did I use formal English (no colloquial or spoken English)?
- Did I write directly in English instead of translating?
- Did I avoid repeating the same words and ideas (concise)?
- Does every sentence have a subject and a verb, including "is/are" where needed?
- Did I proofread for spelling, capital letters and periods?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. The simplest answer is to communicate meaning. People write to inform (news stories, technical manuals) and to entertain (fiction, movie scripts). They also write in daily life (reminder notes, party invitations, love letters), at work (meeting memos, business reports) and at college (paragraphs, essays, research papers, lab reports).
2. Academic writing is a formal, nonfictional written piece of work for learning, teaching, and researching: what students write for their classes in colleges and universities.
3. It is (1) logical and direct: state the main idea first, then the supporting ideas, then a conclusion; (2) formal: use standard English, not colloquial or spoken English; (3) clear: do not translate from your native language, and proofread; (4) concise: do not repeat the same words and ideas unnecessarily.

Exercise 2

1. a 2. b 3. d 4. c 5. c 6. e 7. f (e is also possible) 8. g (e is also possible: the book says your professors and ESL tutors are the best people to help you) 9. h 10. i

11. (example answer) Misconceptions 1 and 4 apply to me. I often translate long sentences from Arabic, and I usually start writing without a plan. The most helpful advice for me is to use the words I already know and to make an outline before I write.

Exercise 3 (book)

1. c 2. g 3. d 4. b 5. f 6. a 7. e

My notes